Sentences and Words

By Cynthia L. Cooper

(A woman stands on the porch of a house that crosses between ramshackley and neat. The setting is small southern Ohio town, which is more southern than northern, and more rural than populated. The woman on the porch, KARLA JACKSON, wears a suit, glasses, blouse and heels. SHE carries a purse and a little file folder. KARLA walks up to the door. SHE bangs loudly on the door several times.)

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Would you be capable of forgiveness if someone you love was brutally murdered? Many who oppose the death penalty claim that vengeance is also a form of violence and that we cannot defend life by taking life.*

ACTRESS 2: *We don't punish robbers by robbing them, or rapists by raping them. Why then do we punish murderers by murdering them? Sentencing someone to "death retaliation" is a more accurate term and, hopefully, more thought-provoking, as is shown in . . .*

TOGETHER: *Sentences and Words by Cynthia L. Cooper*

KARLA: Mrs. Denton! Mrs. Denton, I know you're in there. *(There is no answer.)(KARLA looks at herself and quickly takes off her shoes and exchanges them for beat-up loafers that she is carrying in her purse. She takes off her jacket and stuffs it away in the same purse. SHE knocks again.)* Mrs. Denton. I'll stay here all night if I have to.*(KARLA bangs again, profusely. Now, she becomes conscious of her hair and ruffles it. SHE takes off her glasses and puts them away. She bangs again!)* MRS. DENTON!

(The door opens. A furious MAGGIE DENTON stands at the doorway. SHE is dressed in a very unfancy skirt with a shirt over it. The shirt is hangs outside the skirt. SHE seems a bit disheveled, although SHE has attempted to be neat.)

MAGGIE: Get away from here. Get AWAY!

(MAGGIE quickly slams the door.)(KARLA, undeterred, pulls her shirt out from her skirt.)

KARLA: I've got to have a word with you Mrs. Denton. Tomorrow's the hearing date. For the sentencing. And I've got to talk to you before then.

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(MAGGIE opens the door one more time. KARLA puts her foot into the door opening to prevent MAGGIE from slamming it shut again.)

MAGGIE: You get away or I'm gonna tell my husband to chase you away. You saw what he did last time.

KARLA: He's gone, Mrs. Denton. I saw him drive away. This is just something for you and me.

MAGGIE: We don't have nothing between us, Lady. Nothing.

(MAGGIE tries to slam the door, and to push it shut. KARLA's foot does an admirable, if painful, job of preventing the door from closing entirely. KARLA speaks through the slight opening in the door.)

KARLA: This is a death state, Mrs. Denton. You know what that means, don't you?

MAGGIE: I know what you did in court. I heard what you said about my Tommy. And that was plenty enough for me. Standing up for that dirty old FILTHY OLD SCUZZY OLD SLIMY ROTTEN NASTY DISGUSTING Franklin Miller. I seen plenty.

KARLA: Don't stop, please. Tell me. More. I want to hear.

MAGGIE: You're a whore.

KARLA: You can call me Karla.

MAGGIE: I ain't calling you nothing.

KARLA: May I call you Maggie?

MAGGIE: I'm gonna call the sheriff, you don't get off my porch.

KARLA: I don't think so.

MAGGIE: You don't think what?

KARLA: I don't think you like the sheriff any more than I do.

MAGGIE: You think you know so much. All that education you got.

KARLA: Look ... Maggie. My foot's about to break. You know that defending Mr. Miller was my job. It's my job tomorrow at the sentencing. I'm not pretending anything different. All I want is one minute of your time.

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MAGGIE: He never give Tommy one minute. One minute my Tommy's pitching stones into the field and the next minute he's stabbed behind the shed.

KARLA: You don't have to talk. We can sit. I just need to sit with you before I go back into that courtroom tomorrow. Is that too much to ask? Please?

MAGGIE: *(Emotionally.)*My husband wouldn't allow nobody like you in the house.

KARLA: On the porch then? I'm begging you, Maggie. I know your husband won't speak to me. But, one day, in the courtroom, one day you were sitting in the back, and I turned around, and you looked me straight in the eye and we started to say something that day, just you and me, something silent, something that hasn't been said, and I just have to finish that off.

MAGGIE: I don't recall none of it. If there was any such thing, I probably was making a prayer for you, lady.

KARLA: Will you do it again, then? I know you're a real kind-hearted woman. Maggie?

MAGGIE: One minute. *(MAGGIE reluctantly steps out on to the porch.)*

KARLA: Thank you, ma'am. Thank you very much. *(THEY sit on a soggy couch and moldy chair set out on the porch. There is silence.)* I do have one thing to say.

MAGGIE: You said we didn't have to say nothing. I'm not much for talking with you, lady.

KARLA: Okay. If you could just listen. I'd like to talk.

MAGGIE: I'm just going to pray like I agreed to. That's all. You can say whatever you like, but I'm just going to pray.

KARLA: I'll make it real short. The judge set tomorrow for the sentence. Now, you know, this is a death penalty state. And the judge could sentence Mr. Miller to die. Or he could send him to prison for the rest of his life.

MAGGIE: I'm praying.

KARLA: And as Mr. Miller's attorney, I'm asking that he be sentenced to prison, Maggie.

MAGGIE: I don't have no use for that man. I don't care what they do with him. I don't ever want to hear his name again.

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KARLA: And the judge said ... ahh ... he said that he would leave it to the family about the death penalty. He said if someone from Tommy's family came forward at the hearing and said that Mr. Miller should not get the ...

MAGGIE: I said I didn't ever want to hear his name again.

KARLA: You've known Franklin Miller a long time.

MAGGIE: Too long.

KARLA: Thirty years, I think. I remember something from the file. I thought you might have some feeling of sympathy toward him.

MAGGIE: Towards him! I don't have no feeling of nothing towards him. Let him rot in a pit with birds pecking at his bones, for all I care.

KARLA: You don't care if he's executed?

MAGGIE: NO. NO. I DON'T CARE. AFTER WHAT HE DONE! You want me to care about THAT! I DON'T CARE. ALL I WANT IS MY TOMMY BACK. THAT'S ALL.

KARLA: Alright, Maggie. Okay. See, that's it, then. It's okay. I felt I had a duty to ask. Since that was the condition the judge set ... I had to try. I hope you understand.

MAGGIE: I don't understand nothing, lady. NOTHING.

KARLA: Karla. I'm Karla.

MAGGIE: You want to know what was I thinking that day, lady? I was thinking I was glad I didn't have some big time education so that I didn't have to stand up there like you and defend a dirty vile rotten old man that killed my thirteen year old boy. That's what I was thinking.

KARLA: I see. Sometimes it's not so easy. Especially ... I know this doesn't make much sense ... but Mr. Miller -- I mean I don't say that there was anything right about what happened -- but now I've gotten to know him. He's a friend ... in a way. Maybe I just hate to see people die. Especially clients. Kind of makes me feel like a failure. Like that big time education isn't worth a tire track in the mud.

MAGGIE: Comes with the territory, I imagine.

KARLA: I've never had it happen before. You know, that a client was sentenced to death. Can't make sense out of it.

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MAGGIE: There's no sense in this world, lady. If there was any sense in this world, Tommy would be hollering out back right now.

KARLA: *(Preparing to leave.)* Yes. *(Standing.)* And one thing, Mrs. Denton ...

MAGGIE: I've had enough.

KARLA: I did want to say -- while I'm here, and all -- I want to say, I'm very sorry. About Tommy.

MAGGIE: You're a liar! *(Turns as if to spit.)*

KARLA: What? This is too much. I AM SORRY ABOUT YOUR SON. Good evening, then.

MAGGIE: *(Grabbing her.)* Why you telling me that now, lady?

KARLA: What do you mean?

MAGGIE: No body said that. *(Emotionally)* Not no body.

KARLA: Said what?

MAGGIE: 'Sorry.' I can't hardly believe it myself. Sure, he wasn't no saint. But nobody said they was sorry. Not the funeral man. Not the sheriff. Not the judge. Nobody sitting down there at the county. And nobody 'cept one church lady come knocking out here neither to say their sorries.

(KARLA reaches out to MAGGIE.)

KARLA: Maggie ... I am sorry. And other people -- were. People ... just plain act ... stupid ... sometimes.

MAGGIE: He had a little trouble. So'd his daddy, once or twice. We don't belong to no country clubs or nothing. But they don't have to treat us like we're some trash and it don't mean nothing to us ... do they?

KARLA: Listen to me: You didn't deserve to be treated that way.

MAGGIE: I just want to die, lady. I didn't tell no one this. Not even my husband. I just want to die as soon as have all those cold hearted people talking about my baby and asking questions and have Tommy gone like this.

KARLA: Please. I am so sorry. Oh God. I know ... how it hurts. It's going to hurt. Like a big ball in the middle of your stomach. But, it'll start getting smaller. Over time. Things will get better. Slowly. Believe me.

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MAGGIE: What do you know? This sadness is so thick, I don't know where to put it. I never had nothing like this in my life.

KARLA: I ... had ... there was something ... just last year ... something like it.

MAGGIE: You had a child stabbed bloody?

KARLA: No. No, I didn't have that. It was something different.

MAGGIE: Then you couldn't know. Something different isn't the same.

KARLA: Of course it's not the same. I just know how the hurt feels. It's not the same. Was my little brother, Jack, actually, last year. It was different, of course, and well, he wasn't so little, but he was younger than me. And he got real sick, and they were talking about treatment and other help and ... there are things they can do for people ... you know, it's an epidemic and all, national ... and I don't know, well, he decided he didn't want to go through with it, he just gave up. He ahh ... he ahh ... went into the cellar and ... and ... and ... you ever seen anyone who's hung themselves? It's a hideous awful sight ... a ... horrible ...

MAGGIE: There, there. Stop now.

KARLA: ... and he didn't have to go that way. Not saying goodbye or anything. And I miss him so much. If he were alive, right now, today, I'd be calling him on the phone, crying my eyes out to him. And this is very hard on me ... with Mr. ... with my client and all.

MAGGIE: No ... No... Karla. It won't be so bad. I didn't mean to set you off. Shhh. Shhh. Calm down.

KARLA: *(Straightening up.)* Oh, this is so stupid. Here I am, supposed to be the big professional, and I'm sitting here blathering to you.

MAGGIE: That day ... that day ... when I looked at you. I saw you say you were sorry to me. I saw that in your eyes. You was the only one. And I was a-trying to say thank you.

KARLA: *(Preparing to leave again.)* I appreciate that. *(Turns to exit.)* Well, I'd better be taking my leave before your husband returns. He practically threw the couch at me the last time I came by.

MAGGIE: He's not so bad a man. Everyone hurts.

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KARLA: Sure. I understand. *(Starting to exit.)*

MAGGIE: *(Catches KARLA'S arm.)* When would they do it? ... to ... him.

KARLA: Mr. Miller? Oh, I don't know. I'll still argue, tomorrow, on his behalf. You know, they'll be some people there. His mother, other people. And then there's appeals and all.

MAGGIE: She must be old by now, his mother.

KARLA: Oh, gee. *(Looks in the file.)* Doesn't say exactly. Seventies' I imagine. She's coming from West Virginia ...

MAGGIE: I know where she's coming from.

KARLA: Sure -- that's your country, too. Well, you probably know more than me. *(Shakes MAGGIE'S hand.)* Well, thank you for coming out on the porch.

MAGGIE: I bet your brother Jack walks right along side you sometimes.

KARLA: He does, sometimes.

MAGGIE: I bet he'd be telling you to remember that part where they talk about an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth.

KARLA: Jack wasn't much for religion.

MAGGIE: Yep. I bet Jack'd tell you that's one of the stupidest parts he'd ever heard. I told the preacher that one time too. I think that's stupid I said. That don't accomplish nothing. Just blood on both hands. That's what Jack would say, I bet.

KARLA: He might.

MAGGIE: He'd a probably say what about that part that says thou shalt not kill. What about that? How come nobody talks about that in court?

KARLA: Well, it's a matter of law, you know ...

MAGGIE: And when they wrote that 'thou shalt not' there wasn't no 'ceptions in there for this or for that. I bet he would tell you to bring those things up tomorrow.

KARLA: Well, sure. I can try.

MAGGIE: Good.

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KARLA: Right.

MAGGIE: I'd like to come by and hear that. I don't have any fancy court clothes or anything, but, I'd like to know what the judge says to that. *(KARLA turns to exit.)*

KARLA: Yes, well .... *(KARLA stops, wheels back to MAGGIE, pulls her jacket out of her bag and, puts it on the porch.)* It's not new or ... but ...

MAGGIE: Oh, no. My husband might not approve any business like that. I'd have to ... well, I'd have to step out ...

KARLA: Well, I leave it to you. Jack always liked this jacket. He thought the color was calming. Maybe, I'll just put it here on the porch. Alright then. Thank you. *(KARLA now exits hurriedly.)*

MAGGIE: *(Alone, MAGGIE stands, thinks, picks up jacket, tries it on.)* I'd like to know what that judge says to old Mrs. Miller. I'd like to know that.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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